

INTO ME SEE

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ELIO'S EYES were in excruciating pain. Of course, this had become typical for 11 PM on a Friday night, especially after one drink too many at the local please-notice-me-I'm-single bar: he always found himself downloading Tinder and swiping like crazy. He knew he'd probably delete it the next morning when he re-read the drunken messages he'd sent to girls he actually had no real attraction to. Well, he knew it but also didn't know it; alcohol had a tendency for suppressing knowledge, not to mention morals and values and anything that made a person halfway decent. There was a solid reason why God didn't want Adam and Eve to eat the forbidden fruit; ignorance remained the most reliable way of surviving the vacuous void of human existence.

"Any hot babes lately?" his playful 80-year-old friend Trudy randomly texted him the following afternoon. His charming personality and affection for classic movies had a penchant for attracting women three times his age; if he had been alive in the 1940s, he probably would have been a PLAYER. At first it was kinda cute, but now he kinda resented it; couldn't someone his own age find him attractive?

Okay, that wasn't entirely the truth. Plenty of fellow mid-

twenties women found him appealing enough; they were just never the women whom *he* was attracted to. That was another dangerous thing about swiping through Tinder while drunk, especially when he paid the extra \$13 to see who liked him: he had the potential to become quite the heartbreaker. And this was not something he ever aspired to be; he truly wanted to care about every person he talked to. There was already too much apathy in the world, too many dirty words being tossed around like “networking” and “connections” that painted fellow humans as stepping stones rather than flesh-and-blood creatures with their own unique hopes and dreams and fears. He didn’t need to add to this mess of complacent, comfortable niceness; he strived to be radically, uncomfortably *kind*.

“Hello, Elio!” said Bobby the I’m-still-21 75-year-old at Elio’s favorite West Hollywood coffee shop (yes, he had a penchant for befriending old men too). There was an all-too-rare real smile on his wrinkled face, a face that had too often been victimized by the aforementioned complacent niceness and nodded heads. He sensed that Elio’s interest in him was genuine, and he was going to milk it for all it was worth.

“Hey, Bobby! How’s your week been going?”

“It started off rough, but now it’s alright. Had dinner with my grandson last night and started planning my next trip to Japan.”

“Ooh, Japan!”

“Yes, I’m rather famous over there. I’ve written 13 books on Japanese art.”

“I’d love to read one of them sometime!”

“Sure, I can give you a copy for free.”

“That would be great!” Elio took one more sip of his practically-empty coffee and then leaned forward in his chair,

assuring Bobby that he was still interested in anything more he wanted to share. "I'd love to go to Japan someday."

"I'd be happy to take you sometime."

While Elio knew that Bobby would likely forget this offer, he didn't doubt it was sincere. "That would be great!" This exchange turned out to be the highlight of Elio's whole day; every subsequent conversation was with clock-in-clock-out-faced cashiers at cafes he couldn't afford, plus grumpy bus drivers and one drugged-out dude asking for a cigarette in the subway. Bobby saw something special in Elio that few others seemed to see, something worth pursuing and going out of his way to acknowledge in a coffee shop full of much more visually interesting people; that meant a helluva lot.

Elio didn't go to the bar that night; he went to another coffee shop instead, which later caused him to wake up every hour in bed much more awake than he wanted to be. But it was the lesser of two evils, the gateway drug instead of the drug itself; at least his liver would sing with gratitude. Still he knew that he would probably cave into temptation the next morning, returning to his look-at-me-I'm-single bar of choice and resurrecting his youthful delusions one IPA at a time. Delaying destruction could only do so much; he'd learned not to celebrate moments of self-control, but rather to fear them, to recognize the seductively false portraits of change they painted. Was change even possible though? Maybe not. But he smoked "maybe" like a joint; one had to get high on the possibility of the yes, not the reality of the no.

"I'm glad to hear your daytimes are going well!" Elio's therapist friend Sharon texted him after he gratuitously bore his soul regarding his "sunset slump," the alcoholism-inducing depression that always appeared at roughly 6:00 PM.

He didn't bother responding; he resented the trademark therapist trend of repeating back exactly what was told to them. Were they even listening? Did they actually have a genuine opinion, or were they just reciting what they were supposed to say? They definitely *tried* to sound sincere, he supposed; he couldn't trash people for being the best they knew how to be. But didn't they realize how robotic they sounded, how immune to unfiltered expression?

On Fridays he volunteered as a mentor for a high school creative writing program, and he realized that anyone 18 and under still gave him hope for the future; they had yet to be fully seduced by the comfort of conformity. Sure, social media trends were raging, and it was becoming increasingly hard to raise one's hand in English class for fear of accidentally expressing an unpopular opinion. But there persisted a strand of uniqueness in these kids' interactions, a freshness within the way they saw the world; they remained resistant to the implantation of society's superficial script, the clichéd compass for where to find happiness and fulfillment. Elio sure hoped that this resistance would last as long for them as it had for him; life was too short to live as a carbon copy of an overused blueprint.

Elio's perpetually youthful face (he could still pass for 18) also helped the high schoolers connect with him more than they did the other adults in the mentorship program. His eyes never bore a hint of condescension, never flashed a shade of I-know-more-than-you-about-life. In fact, he actually assumed he knew less than them; the soul-crushing constructs of adulting have a sneaky way of compressing one's education into the bare necessities.

"Do you get paid to do this?" one slightly cynical student named Andrew asked Elio.

"Nope."

"Then why are you here?"

“Because I enjoy talking to you guys.”

Andrew didn’t quite seem convinced, but he decided not to press further. “What do you do other than this?”

“I’m a writer myself actually. Poetry, scripts, short stories, any way I can tell a story.”

“Do you get paid to do it?”

“Haha, not yet. But that’s fine by me; I do it because I love it.”

“I see.” Andrew seemed genuinely inspired by this, although he wouldn’t dare say that.

“Do you do any writing outside of school?” Elio knew that predominantly staying off the prompt of the creative writing program was far more productive than keeping the students focused on the assignment; the whole point was genuine self-expression, and asking “irrelevant” questions helped them do this in the purest form.

“No. But I draw sometimes.”

“That’s awesome! What do you like to draw?”

“Usually people. Sometimes animals.”

“And are they people you know, or imaginary?”

“People I know. If a friend ghosts me, I, uh... I like to draw them so I remember what they were like before they hurt me.”

Elio teared up a little. “That’s beautiful. I do the same thing with poetry.”

Andrew seemed happy that Elio understood, yet his eyes remained melancholic. “But do your friends ever come back?”

Elio teared up even more. “Not usually. But there are exceptions.”

Andrew just nodded his head, understanding Elio without feeling the need to verbally express that he did. Elio then turned to the other students at the table and started asking them similar questions; it was important to acknowledge the significance of each person’s seemingly insignificant interests and hobbies.

Wary about it being a bad example for his high school mentees (even if they didn't know), Elio got drunk that night at his favorite bar and then once again downloaded a slew of dating apps, promptly matching with a mixture of potential bots and "he'll do" hedonists who would undoubtedly be disappointed when they learned of his relatively inexperienced sexual status. He wasn't quite sure why he made this scandalous choice; his day had actually been fairly good, especially after the boost that mentoring the high schoolers gave him. But no matter what, he lost motivation to do anything productive after 6 PM, and getting wasted seemed more fruitful than going to bed pathetically early. At least he usually wound up writing some halfway decent lines of poetry while intoxicated, plus a paragraph or two in a short story. But the subsequent numbing of his soul – the genuinely awful pickup lines slung at partially interested women, the compulsive porn searches and mindless masturbation – never ended up being worth it the next morning. Maybe it was better to go to bed at 6:00 with his soul still intact.

Beyond the appeal of the buzz itself, Elio loved going to bars for the candid people-watching it provided. Usually both the bar patrons and the bartenders were in the same boat: ready to be discovered by someone who cherished them exactly as they were. He eavesdropped on many a gentle flirtation, many a coded rejection that sounded like an invitation to come back the next night slightly more well-combed and baritone-voiced. A few people were successful, but most were not; how else would such places stay in business? Capitalism fed on isolation, after all.

Of course, when he woke up the next morning, Elio vowed never to get drunk again. His hangover wasn't even that bad, and his typical drunk habits had been kept to a

minimum, but he still couldn't escape the prevalent grossness seeping at his core. He had spent almost the whole first quarter of his life sober, and it wouldn't be too hard to return to this pure Eden state, would it?

Glancing over at his phone on the night stand, his heart suddenly leaped with excitement; there were a few stream-of-consciousness messages from the person he had been waiting in vain to receive messages from all week: Marian Harris. The one who got away, even though she technically hadn't gotten away yet.

She was responding to a text Elio had sent eight days ago. For most people, more than a two-day lag in response was a sign of ghosting, but not for Marian; she was gifted/cursed with a sort of lightyear affection, showing her warmth and enthusiasm at a relatively slow but ultimately powerful rate, more powerful than the average good-how-are-you robot. Elio even had to learn how to proofread and reconsider anything he sent her, as she was bound to analyze every little detail and answer in a most literal sense.

Hey! Sorry for the late response, it's been a crazy week. Aww, I'm so glad you still love the Christmas hand-warmers despite them being broken! I'm touched that the malfunctioning gift meant so much in its unassuming symbol/representation of warmth and care. I try to pick up on, and remember lol, some things that are important to you/could come in handy bebe. It made me sad thinking about your hands shriveling up in the Illinois winter vortex-like wind when you visited family.

God, do you realize how hard it is not to fall in love with you? Elio immediately thought. He and Marian had already

had the damning discussion on more than one occasion; it was not possible for them to transcend their friendship-with-emotional-but-no-physical-closeness status right now. Marian was busy exploring intimate, potentially sexual connections with women, and she was in no rush to put a constrictive label on a relationship with yet another man who might end up letting her down. She knew that Elio loved her, may even be crazy about her, and she didn't seem to mind; he supposed that said something about the door not being completely closed. But at the present moment, they'd have to continue going through the recognizable motions of a relationship without actually being in one; this appeared like a piece of cake for Marian, but it was profoundly difficult for Elio.

Anyhow, he tried to keep his options open, flirting with the occasional anti-status quo barista and free spirit bookseller who made his heart flutter, despite the conversation predominantly consisting of "I'll have a small vanilla latte with almond milk" or "Do you have any Oscar Wilde in stock?" He never really got anywhere – considering the world's divorce rate, who really did? – but it was the journey that counted, right? Destinations were rare even for those who pretended otherwise; there was no shame in being so close but still so far.

Sometimes the bathroom mirror was the most terrifying thing in the world. Especially the one in Elio's apartment, which seemed to highlight every awkward feature and obliterate the remnants of handsomeness he thought he'd caught in the bar restroom (although three beers may have had something to do with that). He was a hopeless cause! No no, that was just self-pity talking, and he had to transcend it. Pity was immediate and effortless, which was why it remained far more common than love; it only required

acknowledging the problem, not actually finding tangible solutions for it. Elio was determined to really love himself, which sometimes meant challenging himself, or at the very least being patient; he might be having a rough day, but that was no reason to sulk, because better days were coming along!

Although he was admittedly a little scared for his future. All around him were reminders of what he was in danger of becoming someday: an overly perky middle-aged bartender complimenting every halfway pretty patron's shirt, a pathetically nice coffee shop regular mistaking casual conversation for flirtation, a well-dressed old man smiling at anyone and everyone who might entertain his fragile fantasy of being wanted. Elio knew that he had to conquer his delusions early, or else they would always remain; the acceptance of perpetual loneliness was sometimes the price of sanity and decency.

Anyhow, he channelled his British ancestry and adopted a stiff upper lip, refusing to resort to self-pity any longer. He also channelled his inner French philosopher and started analyzing the etymological roots of the word "intimacy." Did it actually mean, "Into me SEE?" He googled it and found articles by a couple of pretentious psychotherapists who'd come to the same etymological conclusion that he'd had. This admittedly lowered his self-esteem; he thought he was original. Nevertheless, it was also comforting, although he would never admit it of course; at least he wasn't alone in his pretentious self-pity. We all just wanted to be seen and cherished exactly as we were; therein lay the quest for God, the quest for something beyond this eternally unsatisfying life.

"I want out," Elio told the bathroom mirror on one particularly depressing evening. He wasn't typically suicidal, but he'd had enough of nothingness, the slavery of same-old-same-old.

“Well, you can’t leave just yet,” the mirror seemed to reply.

Oh, how pathetically optimistic, Elio thought with slight resentment. *YOU try being a hopelessly romantic writer for a living.* He had no intention of actually ending his life, but he liked entertaining the idea every now and then; no matter what, it was comforting to remember that he was gonna die someday.

“You’re so different than everyone else.”

“Alright, Satan.” Elio had learned to take his “inner confidence” voice with a grain of salt. Although it was tempting to believe it was legitimately God...

“Think about tomorrow.”

“That’s exactly the point. I don’t want to think about tomorrow.”

“I know, but from the amount you’ve drank and eaten in the name of 30-second satisfaction, you really should.”

“Okay okay, that’s a fair point.” *Damn, you’re blunt.* Maybe his reflection really WAS God. Or maybe he should just go to bed.

“You are enough.”

“Are you quoting my cheesy sweatshirt?”

“Maybe...”

Elio admittedly chuckled. “But aren’t I really MORE than enough?”

“If you say so.”

“Rude!!”

“I can’t be anything but honest.”

“Well, honesty is mean.”

“But dishonesty is meaner.”

“Touche.”

Starting to worry he might be going crazy, Elio turned away from his mirror friend and headed to bed. He was unusually tired and fell asleep rather quickly; this was nice for

a change. Although he wasn't sure he really earned the fatigue; his day hadn't been particularly productive. But what did "productivity" even mean anyway? Hell, just getting out of bed could be considered productive; he needed to stop holding himself to such lofty standards. What was it Abe Lincoln supposedly said? *"It's not the years in your life that count, but the life in your years."* Elio tried to live by these words, but it was pretty damn hard; going to bed at 9 PM and waking up at 7:30 AM always seemed pathetic, even if he had been fairly productive the previous day.

The next evening, he and the ever-elusive Marian went on a hike in Griffith Park. The sun was setting, which didn't help Elio's helplessly hopeless romanticism. Marian even insisted on hearing some of his latest poetry at the top of the hill, then proceeded to lean in closer and smile a beguiling smile; was she fooling herself as much as he was?

"We should sing a song," Elio suggested after reading a couple poems, bubbling with liquid courage despite having no alcohol in his system. They were about to descend the hill in complete darkness, and he figured a song would distract them from the potential danger. Although they also both craved danger...

"Haha, what song?"

"How about 'Colors of the Wind?' Pocahontas is your favorite Disney princess, isn't she?"

"You remembered! Haha sure. But you start."

"Okay." Elio channeled his best singing voice. "You think you own whatever land you land on..."

"The earth is just some dead thing you can claim..."

"But I know every rock and tree and creature..."

"Has a life..."

"Has a spirit..."

"Has a NAME..."

They continued singing with blissful sloppiness as they

ran down the hill. Marian was impressed by how well Elio remembered all the lyrics, even better than she did; he must have been a closeted “Disney Adult.” Once they reached the bottom of the hill, they had a subtly hard time saying goodbye. “Well... This was fun.”

“Yeah. Hope to do it again soon.” They said this every time, and Elio always worried it might be a lie; he had been unexpectedly ghosted by too many people in the past.

Ultimately, he knew there was nothing between them, at least not what he wanted to be there. Were all the necessary ingredients present? Sure. But they weren’t in the correct order or even in the same mixing bowl, and they probably never would be. He deserved better than to wait around with a hopeful smile, convinced the Master Chef of Fate would gradually set things right. It was nobody’s fault really; it was simply that he recognized a perfect recipe immediately, and she remained perpetually convinced that a better one might be waiting in the neighbor’s kitchen.

“Into me see,” Elio prayed before going to bed that night. It had been a while since he had legitimately prayed, but surely somebody was up there listening; the universe was too complex to be completely arbitrary. “Into me SEE,” he repeated, now sounding a little desperate. He was in no rush to become a priest or monk or anything like that, but with each passing day; it seemed increasingly unlikely that any human would offer the level of intimacy he craved to a nearly suicidal level; divine love might be all he had left to hope in.

But no answer came, which he expected. He was simply trying faith out for size like he once did as a Santa Claus-believing, God-fearing child; he was happier back then, wasn’t he? Or maybe he was drunk on the most dangerous liquor of

all, nostalgia. The past was only happy in proportion to how miserable we feared the future to be.

Closing his eyes, Elio was about to drift off to sleep when his phone started to buzz. Could it be Marian? Nah, eight days hadn't passed by yet. And even if it was her, she probably wouldn't be texting anything he wanted to hear unless he projected to an extreme. Taking out the anxiety-inducing rectangle, he unlocked the screen and saw it showed a text from a frequently-depressed childhood friend who confided in him on a regular basis. She knew he wouldn't give her the canned responses she received from everyone else, that he would readily admit he didn't know how to help her, and for this reason, she felt more helped by him than most other compassionate people in her life.

The text was a coded cry for affirmation, for confirmation that she wasn't crazy in how sad she felt every day. As he read through the message a second time, a flood of peace briefly washed over Elio's soul. Perhaps this was the answer to his prayer, as reluctant as he remained to accept it: it was his destiny to see others without any guarantee he'd be seen in return. This would feel like a curse most of the time, but he ultimately understood it was a gift, a gift that formed the crux of his whole personhood, his predominant purpose in this fleeting life.

Smiling through his disappointed tears, he began typing the most imperfectly perfect, helplessly helpful response he could muster.